

CONFLICT OF POSITIVE VERSUS NEGATIVE ORIENTED PLEASURE PRINCIPLE AS THE ORIGIN OF PAIN

Greetings, my dearest, dearest friends. Blessings again for each and every one of you, for every step, for every effort you undertake on your road to liberation.

As a preface to tonight's lecture, I should like to discuss the meaning of pain, or the real cause of pain. Pain is the result of conflict. It is when two opposite directions exist in a personality that pain comes into being. One direction -- the direction of the universal, creative forces -- strives towards light, life, growth, unfoldment, affirmation, beauty, love, inclusion, union, pleasure supreme. Whenever this direction is counteracted by another direction, a disturbance is created. It is not the disturbance itself that creates the pain, but it is the opposite direction which brings imbalance and a special sort of tension. It is this which causes the suffering. This is very important to understand, my friends, because with this understanding, it will be easier to follow the rest of this lecture.

The principle I explain here holds true on all levels. On the physical level, it is indeed ascertainable. The physical system, as all other systems or planes, also strives towards wholeness and health. When a disturbing force pulls into an opposite direction, it is the existence of the two directions that creates the pain. It is ascertainable that this is what actually causes the pain by the fact that when struggle is given up and when the individual lets go and gives in to the pain, the pain stops. Many people have verified the truth of this principle. The moment that struggle, two opposite pulls, is relinquished and even the negative direction (pain) accepted, pain must cease.

When the disturbance is fought against in an ineffective manner, although it wants health, it negates the fact that it also wants nonhealth. Since the nonhealth aspect is repressed and ignored, the struggle towards health becomes all the more tense. That is the pain. If the personality were conscious of wanting nonhealth, as well as health, the struggle would cease instantly, for the former wish cannot be maintained. Only the latter can. It is the unconscious aspect which creates a gap between cause and effect, the cause being the negative wish, the effect the disturbance in the system. The two pulls continue, and pain comes into being.

But when what goes on is fully understood and the temporary, still unavoidable, consequences of the negative wish accepted, and one lets oneself go into this now existing pain, the pain must cease. This is not necessarily a destructive way of embracing pain or a masochistic, self-punishing element that in itself harbors and perpetuates a negative wish. What I mean is a full acceptance of what is -- and with that, pain ceases. It is the principle, for instance, of painless birth. It is the principle of nonstruggle. It is the principle that Jesus Christ explained when He said, "Resist not evil."

When the struggle is too fierce (on all levels), death sets in. Or death may be a result of having given up the struggle. This applies to the physical plane, of course. Therefore physical pain ceases when tension ceases -- and this happens in death.

On the mental and emotional planes, something similar exists. When the struggle is fully understood and accepted as a temporary manifestation, as an effect, and is accepted as such -- without finality and yet in awareness of the rightfulness of these consequences -- the mental or emotional pain ceases. This does not happen when the negative is wanted; for, as we have seen, this merely creates the new direction, contrary to the original, positive one. Nor does this happen by forfeiting the affirmative principle as such, but in the understanding of the now. Then mental and emotional pain cease just as physical pain ceases when the opposite pull is abandoned. All this is verifiable and has been verified the world over. All of you who are on such a path of self-realization have at least occasionally experienced this.

On the spiritual plane, my friends, it is different. For, the spiritual plane is the cause, while all other planes or spheres of consciousness are effects. The spiritual plane is the origin of the positive direction. It does not and could not contain a negative direction. The negative direction creates and is created by different attitudes incompatible with the origin of all life. The spiritual plane is unity itself; therefore conflict, opposing directions, and, consequently, pain is unthinkable and illogical.

If a person is free from conflict and pain, he must be in unity. He can be in total unity only when he follows the unbroken line of the positive direction of his life forces. If it were possible for an individual entity to fully want the negative, pain too would cease. But this is not possible, for the real self is attuned to the real world of absolute constructiveness. This is the final reality so that it is virtually senseless to even imagine that anyone could be in unity about any negative aim. Life, in its essential and profound character, cannot ever be negatively oriented. Negative orientation cannot be anything but a distortion. Since, underneath distortion, the real continues to exist, it sends forth its effects regardless of the overlayers of distortion and the strength of the momentarily existing negative orientation. Since man and life are one, he cannot ever be fully negative. Whenever there is some negation in his make-up, tension and conflict must exist, so that he must be in pain. The negating direction is opposed to life, and nonlife cannot ever be wholly, totally, and conflictlessly desired or even envisaged, for it makes no sense.

It is very important to understand, my friends, that the negative can only be desired by a part of the personality, never by the whole of it. There will always be another part of the psyche which violently objects to the negative desire, so that pain must result. On the physical as well as on the emotional and mental levels, it is possible temporarily to accept the negative as a passing stage in the understanding that it is the effect of an inadvertent cause and a momentary disturbance. In this understanding and acceptance, one ceases the struggle. One accepts the negative without finality and with an objective, non-self-indulgent attitude. But on the spiritual plane, which comprises the total being, total life, the origin of all, this is impossible. The total being cannot ever totally want the negative. Pain and suffering are always the result of two directions, of the personality being pulled in two directions, the life and the antilife directions, the love and hate, isolation, fear directions, the positive and negative directions. The outer layers of personality must suffer as long as unity is not achieved -- and unity exists exclusively in the reality of the cosmic creative principle. It is exceedingly important, my friends, to understand what I am saying here, for this understanding must open new doors.

In recent weeks and months, a number of my friends have crossed a major threshold on their path in the discovery and awareness of where they themselves desire the negative. Now, this is an exceedingly important new phase. It makes all the difference for an individual to be aware or not to be aware of his negative desires. There are, of course, degrees of awareness. It is possible to be aware of them casually and fleetingly. It is possible to have gained one important insight of their existence, and this awareness dilutes again. The more the awareness of a deliberate desire for the negative exists, the more will you be in control of yourself, of life, and the less will you feel victimized, helpless, and weak. When an entity is not aware of this deliberate desire for the negative, the suffering must be infinitely greater than any suffering or pain that can ensue when one is aware of having wanted it oneself. Lack of such awareness must create a psychic climate in which the individual feels he is singled out to be a victim. It is inevitable to feel helpless when one lacks awareness of the fact that the effect was self-created. Separation between cause and effect in one's consciousness must create confusion, doubt, and hopelessness. The moment awareness of the negative desire has been attained through the painstaking struggle of this work, you at least know, my friends, what causes your outer difficulties and unwelcome situations. Even before you are capable of giving up the negative desires because you do not yet understand the reason for their existence, the mere fact that you know that you have created the undesirable manifestations in your life will render you a freer person.

Those of you who have made these initial inroads in awareness of the negative desires must be careful to extend this awareness and to link and connect it with the unwelcome manifestations in your life. This essential step must not be overlooked. For it is indeed possible to be aware, to some extent at least, of a negative desire and nevertheless ignore or overlook that this negative desire is the immediate cause of any number of manifestations in your life which you strenuously oppose and struggle against. And that is exactly your pain. You struggle against something that you have yourself induced and continue to induce, while, at the same time, there must always be the pull towards the light, towards wholeness, towards loving, inclusion, and constructiveness, towards beauty and unfoldment. Your denial of the direction towards wholeness and your oblivion of this denial, your not knowing that you deny it, your not knowing that you want two opposing things at the same time is what confuses and pains you. It will easily be seen what is required for an entity to reach this awareness and understanding.

Those of you who have begun to see the first beginnings of your negative desires have gained a new strength and a new hope whenever this awareness is alive, dynamic, and not pushed out of sight. For then, indeed, at first as a principle and as a possibility, you see how it can be when you no longer have the negative desire even though you do not yet know why and how you insist on the negative desires and why you harbor them in the first place. But the mere fact of knowing that you have them and subsequently connecting them with the unwelcome results must give you new hope and a new outlook.

Those friends who have not yet gained this awareness should try their very, very best to find the existence of their negative desires. On the surface, the majority of people cannot imagine how they might harbor destructive desires. Even some friends who are on this path for a long time may as yet be unable to feel their destructive direction. Meditate and truly want to find what is in you. This is even more difficult in a personality who busily denies those aspects in his life that leave something to be desired and who does not want to face that he missed something, that he suffers

from something. This kind of denial of what he really feels and misses makes it impossible ever to bring real fulfillment into his life. This denial of what is, at the moment, still exists in a few of my friends who have been in this work for a considerable time. So ask yourself, "Do I have, do I experience, everything to the maximum of my potentials? What is it that possibly disturbs me more than I admit?" That would be the first question. This is a pertinent question for those whose tendency it is to escape from their unfulfillments, to deny them, to gloss over them and falsify their situation. And then of course there are those people who are only too keenly aware of their suffering and of what they miss, but in themselves they are disconnected from the mechanism that wishes the negative result.

Here the work on this path continues. The finding and the awareness of deliberate negative desires or the avoidance of positive results (which amounts to the same thing) is, as you can see, an essential milestone on your whole road of evolution. This is practically more important than anything else. For, it constitutes the difference between feeling oneself a helpless straw in the wind, a little tool in a vast universe, forgotten and helpless, and feeling oneself to be self-governing, autonomous. This autonomy works in the positive as well as in the negative way. The entire cosmos exists by the great principle of self-perpetuation. Whenever we discussed the principle of cycles or circles -- whether the benign or the vicious -- it is always the principle of self-perpetuation. Everything is self-perpetuating, set in motion by reality consciousness.

Again, this can be ascertained on your path. When you come to a certain degree of insight into your psyche, you see how the positive and negative attitudes are self-perpetuating. Take, for example, any healthy, positive attitude. When you are outgoing, constructive, open, including, all things go easily. You do not have to work hard at it. It perpetuates itself. You do not even have to spend energy on any deliberate kind of meditation. By themselves, your positive thoughts, attitudes, and feelings create more positive thoughts, attitudes, and feelings. Hence fulfillment, productiveness, peace, dynamism exist in such an area. It is exactly the same with the negative situations. The self-perpetuating forces, in this instance, can only be changed by this deliberate process which sets something new in motion. The process of such pathwork accomplishes this.

It is further important for you to understand and visualize that the spheres of consciousness in existence operate exactly according to these directions that we have heretofore discussed. In other words, to simplify a bit for the sake of our discussion here, there is the positive principle and direction. This is the sphere of reality, the sphere in which there is unlimited self-perpetuation in whatever respect consciousness is aware of its existence. Incidentally, I want to interject here that the principle of self-perpetuation I have here explained on a spiritual level exists in identical form on a scientific plane. In chemistry, in physics, in practically every field of science, this principle can be found to exist. Therefore it should be easier to accept than if it were a phenomenon that had not already been found to exist in human material realms.

The personality level which wants the negative and pursues its direction creates a new world, or psychic sphere, covering the original one. Images and forms -- the product of attitudes, thoughts, and feelings -- create this negative world. There are many variations, degrees, and possibilities according to the strength of the negative desires, the awareness of both positive and negative desires, and the balance between the two. You may gain an inkling of this by looking at your own change from the point of view of awareness as compared with your previous unconscious denial of positive experience, or even of a direct desire for the negative one. Compare this with your present

awareness, and you will see that this difference constitutes a different sphere of consciousness, a different world -- each distinct with its own flavor and atmosphere.

The physical, material world you live in is the exact expression of a certain mixture which manifests the positive, the negative, and a combination of the two. All of these worlds exist in and outside of you -- in timelessness and spacelessness. You can reach these worlds within your psyche -- you must reach these worlds in the sense of becoming acutely aware of them. They are a product of your own expressions, of your various spheres of consciousness. You must go through them, layer by layer, within yourself. Where you are relatively free from negative desires, it will be relatively simple and easy to grasp, to feel, to experience the world of truth where all good exists and is self-perpetuating. Therefore there is no need for struggle, for doubt, for fear, or for deprivation. In these areas, you will find that you fearlessly open your heart to the positive, dynamic experience which moves eternally towards further unfoldment, greater happiness, more inclusion. You do not stop this movement with your fearful mind, holding it in check and bringing it to a standstill. These spheres are there. They not only exist deep in your psyche where you can sense the eternal life of all existence, but they manifest in your outer life. To become aware of them is also useful so that you can compare properly.

And then of course there is always the main problem, the area in your psyche where the fear of the positive, hence its negation, exists. Consequently, deprivation and suffering manifest in your outer life. It is this sphere within your consciousness that you must fully experience so that you can transcend it. You must live it through, not by denying it or struggling away from it, but by seeing and accepting it, by learning to understand its nature. This is what is meant by going through it. When it is affirmed and ascertained as a temporary reality, only then can the underlying world of self-perpetuating good be reached, where you no longer have to reach and grasp and want, but where you know it is already yours even before you have attained it.

Whenever man is separated from others, from his fellow creatures, he must be in the negative world, in a self-perpetuating negativity he sows through his destructive wishes. He must therefore be in suffering because he denies and ignores the full significance of the thus evolving struggle. Man finds himself in this constant struggle. The struggle varies from individual to individual, and with one individual from phase to phase, and even, at times, from hour to hour because at different times, the different directions come up. They alternate in predominance at any given moment. At one time, one direction is more on the surface and the other more submerged, at other times it changes. So there must always be in you the unceasing struggle in which one side strives towards wholeness and union with your fellow creatures, in many different ways, towards love and understanding, towards consideration, towards giving and receiving. But always there still is this other side which negates and denies the former direction, which fears and resists it. Therefore a particular pain exists -- the greater the denial, the greater the pain. For, do not forget, it is impossible to completely want isolation, withdrawal, and separation. If it were possible to fully want this and be wholly reconciled to its results, there would be no pain. But it is not possible totally to ever want this. One can only want it to a large degree. And therefore the larger the percentage, the stronger the pull into the opposite direction from health and union -- hence, the fiercer the pain.

Now, the pain is aggravated by the struggle that sets in with the other person. For, do not forget, my friends, it is painful enough that you want and do not want, alternately, to relate and love on the one hand and to hate, reject, and withdraw on the other. It becomes infinitely more

complicated and conflicting when this is multiplied by a second individual into whose circumference you enter and who wages a similar fight within.

Both the positive and negative directions are attached to the pleasure principle, as I have outlined in a previous lecture. It is this attachment that makes it so difficult to give up and change. The positively and negatively oriented pleasure principle tears man apart. It inflicts pain on you by itself, but it does not exist in you alone. Those with whom you are involved in this conflict, about whom you cannot decide whether or not to love or to reject, if they were perfectly in balance and free from such an inner division, they would surely not be affected by your struggle. Their harmony with the universal forces and the high degree of awareness would protect them from negativity and the resulting tension between the positive and negative pulls. For the sake of argument, if it were possible that such an evolved being could enter into a relationship with an ordinary person who is racked by this fight, the latter would still be in pain by his own division. But how much more complicated does it become when the other person is in a similar position, for then the struggle is not twofold, but a compounded fourfold one. Imagine the many mathematical possibilities that arise from such a situation, with all their psychological consequences of misunderstanding, misjudgment, and hurts, which in turn create further negativity. Let us imagine two people, A and B. A momentarily expresses the positive direction towards union. B is frightened of it and therefore withdraws and rejects A. Consequently, A convinces himself all over again that the healthy soul movement toward union was risky and painful so that he reverts to the negative and the denial. Since it is so painful, the negative pleasure principle attaches itself to it so as to make the pain more bearable. He will then revel in the negative situation. In the meantime, the pain of isolation in B becomes unbearable, and he ventures out while, at that time, A is in his dark hole. Now, this goes on and on, sometimes in crass opposition, sometimes there is a fleeting meeting. At times, A's positive direction meets B's negative one; at other times, it is reversed; at still other times, both negative currents are out, both withdraw or antagonize one another. At still other times, both temporarily venture into the positive, but since the negative principle still exists in them, the positive position is only tentative, so uncertain, so fearful, so divided, so defensive and apprehensive that all these negative emotions about the positive direction are found to produce negative results sooner or later. These are then attributed to the positive reaction rather than to the problematic emotions about it. It is inevitable that the negative direction must again take over after such periods of mutual positiveness until the negative destructive and denying side is fully understood and eliminated.

This again brings together a number of the recent lectures into one comprehensive whole, as you can easily see. As I outlined in a recent lecture, the negative, the denial, the destructive direction would not be as fierce and as difficult to overcome if the pleasure principle were not attached to it. Man then comes into the position of not wanting to part from the precarious pleasure he derives from indulging in destructive feelings and attitudes. This may come into existence subtly, insidiously, and inadvertently when an individual starts out with the healthy and constructive direction in force.

Let us take the following example, which might prove useful for all of you. Suppose on your road towards self-realization, you gain strength and self-confidence. Where there was uncertainty and guilt in you when you experienced friction with another person, you now experience a new inner calm, certainty in yourself, and a strength and resiliency you never knew existed. In the old way, you might have responded with submissiveness in order to assuage your guilt or with aggression and hostility in order to assuage your self-contempt for your uncertainty. Whatever you

did, however you responded with the negativity and self-doubt in you, you were involved in the negatively oriented pleasure principle. You enjoyed your woes. Now, you have progressed. You experience yourself in a new way. Instead of the nagging self-doubt, you gain insight into the other person. By this insight, you understand why the other person behaves as he does, what makes him tick. For the moment, this objective understanding sets you free, makes you strong, gives you more objective insight into yourself and into the other person. In other words, the self-perpetuating principle of insight and understanding has been put in motion.

But then the still existing, because not yet fully recognized, negative pleasure principle attaches itself to your understanding of the other person's negativity. You begin to talk yourself into more and more of his faults and blindnesses, and you inadvertently begin to enjoy this. You do not immediately distinguish between the two different kinds of joy: the first, when you saw the detachment, what exists in the other, setting you free; the second, when you pleasurably indulge in the other's wrongness, blinding you. What you first noticed as observations, you build up and build up until the old negative pleasure principle has reappeared in a new guise. This is where you lose your harmony and freedom because you again indulge in the negative pleasure principle. This is an example of how insidiously this can happen whenever the old roots still exist, unobserved.

Now, my friends, the continuation of the path becomes clearer and more concisely defined. You have the immediate tools to set out and see what I explained here. Now, are there any questions?

QUESTION: It seems this whole lecture was for me. Whenever I come to see the pain and hurt in the other person, I immediately bring out the negative, hostility and rage, and I am blinded by these negative feelings. I cannot see anything positive or understand the struggle in the other person. Although I pray and want to let go, I am still "sitting in the hole."

ANSWER: Are you aware that while you indulge in the negativity that you enjoy doing it?

QUESTION: Yes, I am.

ANSWER: The next step would have to be a very simple one, my dearest friend. That is the issuance and expression of the thought: "I want to give up the negative. I want my pleasure to be attached to a positive situation. I want to be constructive. I want to give my attention to this situation and be governed by the most constructive forces." Do this in a relaxed and light way, enlisting the subliminal forces within yourself to help you do it. Do not try to do it by sheer outer power, for with that outer power you cannot succeed. I also explained this recently. Your outer mind can only issue such a constructive intent and with that it sets up a positive movement which then begets a positive self-perpetuating cycle. If you are not yet willing to do it, the work must proceed very simply and easily. Where and why do you believe that wanting the negative is safer for you than wanting the positive? You hinder yourself from wanting the positive. If you cannot stop this process, there must still be reasons you have not understood, and they must be unearthed.

QUESTION: Irrationally, I fear that I may be taken advantage of and lose my integrity. I have a slight feeling that this is not true, but I can't see exactly how.

ANSWER: In the first place, you must truly want to see that this is possibly a wrong conclusion. The feeling of helplessness or powerlessness is again the self-perpetuating principle in that you have given up self-government when you allowed yourself to be taken up by the negative force. Therefore it does not occur to you that you have the possibility of governing yourself. The moment, for instance, you say, "I decide that I do not want to be in negativity or hang on to misconceptions, such as these," in that moment you take command. Then, further, if you say and mean, "I do not have to be a slave to decisions that do not come from me because I am constructive. It is up to me whatever I want." You will then experience that the more constructive your desires are, the freer do you become, and the easier will it be to determine independently what you will or will not do. Others will not be able to impose their will on you, hence your integrity will be preserved and increased in exact proportion to your active desire to be constructive and to give up the negatively attached pleasure principle. What weakened you was the loss of awareness of your negative desires. You had repressed, denied, and hidden them, having superimposed false positive ones. Hence you lost touch with yourself. Had you been aware of the negative desires, you would not have been able to let them grow so strong. But even if you had done that, you would not have become helpless and powerless. In reality, your weakness and helplessness does not exist in regard to the stronger will of the others. It exists because you are swept up in the negative self-perpetuating force of your negative desires which you have consciously ignored until now. This lack of control makes you unable to imagine how it is when you take command. Now, you, with your conscience and your spirit, cannot take command consciously in negative desires. This can happen only by positive desires. When you issue such positive desires, you will therefore become stronger and more self-governing and less helpless -- and therefore it will be impossible to be taken advantage of because your free and active decisions will be made in absolute consciousness of what you are doing and why. Another thing is that just because of the gnawing guilt -- which is inevitable when negative desires exist whether or not one is aware of them -- you allow yourself to be taken advantage of. The guilt makes you go overboard. It is exactly because of the negative direction in you that you do allow yourself to be taken advantage of, that you are uncertain, uneasy, and weak about any of your rights -- only because of that! Were you free from the destructive desires, you would not be guilty, hence you would not need to atone. And you could very easily, kindly, and without defensiveness, occasionally, when it is the right thing and when this is what you want, say no and not give in to demands being made upon you. So, it is exactly the opposite from the way you think. Positiveness will set you free to have integrity, to defend and assert your rights, while negation and destructiveness must weaken you and make you defenseless. When it is as yet impossible to issue the desire to be constructive and positive, assert that this is where you are. Assert this fact. See yourself being in the negation and destructiveness, and set out to find what further undetected reason slumbers behind this resistance. Arrayed behind are more fears of a deeper nature which we will come to and which I shall discuss in the future.

QUESTION: I usually concentrate too much on studying the negative aspects, centered on the father image. I have asked myself lately if by doing so I have been hiding something which is deeper in me and that I don't want to look at. I concentrate on this mixture of a father image and a concept of maleness. I think I miss the main point by analyzing too much of this.

ANSWER: There is somewhere a desire in you in which you do not want to assume the male role. Have you become aware of this desire?

QUESTION: No.

ANSWER: Well, this is it. Awareness of it will come, maybe indirectly by deducing certain manifestations first and subsequently bringing out the emotions. Consciously, there is the great desire to be a strong man. You even go overboard and exaggerate this image of masculinity as a consequence of overcompensation. This overcompensation would not exist if you were deeply ready to assume the male role, if you would not refuse it. There is this fear that you may be too inadequate to fulfill this role; there is the fear of demands to be made upon you by assuming it. And also there is a sort of a spitefulness towards life, towards society, wherein you say no. There is an envy in you of the feminine sex, which on that level seems to have it easier. You resent the effort required of you to fill in this conscious male image. You believe that this is what you should do, and you resent that this seems to be expected of you. Maybe you expect it of yourself, but nevertheless, this is what you think you ought to do and be -- and you resent it. So, it is important that you find the exact opposite of the conscious striving, where you make passive resistance against your male role, where you fear it, deny it, and do not want it and spitefully refuse it. When you become aware of that, you will know and have found the point I have discussed tonight. Then you will be aware of your main negative desires. This, of course, concerns your identity as a man.

QUESTION: Yes, yes. I went over this point last year, but I have completely overlooked it lately.

ANSWER: Yes, this is what happens so often. A finding is made, and it is then shelved as though this suffices. It is not by any means changed or eliminated. In fact, you have scratched the bare surface of this facet. It is often necessary that one works on other aspects for a while before one can return to the fundamental problem.

Be blessed, every one of you. Receive this warm stream of love that is all around you and transcends every one of you. Open yourself. For, this love is truth, and this truth is life. And this life is yours for the asking. The courageous steps all of you undertake here have meaning. They are not senseless, they are not useless, my dearest ones. May you always know this. Every admission of something negative that exists in you contributes more towards the universal process of wholeness than any other thing imaginable. So proceed this way. Be blessed. Be in peace. Be in God!

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